cooperation and its growing relevance to key global debates underlines how far the relationship has now come. While important in themselves, the understanding on transfer of technology for jet engines and the collaborative steps in the semiconductor domain hold a symbolism far beyond. American business is beginning to overcome its long-standing scepticism about India, just as its military is learning to work with a non-alliance culture. Its strategic community is displaying a better understanding of India's value as its technology sector appreciates the significance of closer collaboration. Truly, the relationship has now moved into a higher orbit.

Although the ties have undergone a profound change, some of the divergences of the past need to be borne in mind to navigate the future in a better way. A large part of the contradiction between the interests of the two nations arose from the traditional American approach to the Indian subcontinent. The interest in hyphenating India and Pakistan and seeking to influence their bilateral dealings has been an entrenched attitude. The deliberate permissiveness with regard to Pakistan's nuclear programme in the 1980–90s was its most extreme manifestation. The US presence in Afghanistan also created new factors of regional dependency that were not in harmony with its India relationship.

Moreover, the global outlook of the US was often on a different wavelength from the security and economic interests of India. Even on the nuclear account, the 2005 understanding did not always set to rest more doctrinaire American advocacy in that domain. It was also natural that the worldview, policies and diplomacy of two partners, one developed and the other still developing, would differ on a range of socio-economic issues. Nor was it unexpected that a dominant prescriptive polity should rub against a sensitive sovereignty-conscious society.

Indeed, some of these very traits combined to create challenges for the relationship in 2013–14. But structural changes underway, along with policy optimism, came together to ensure that ties returned to their upward trajectory and stayed that way. It is not that the two nations do not have differences; what has changed is the willingness to nevertheless find common ground and pursue mutual advantage. Indeed, it has been an example of how an open-minded appreciation of contemporary changes has refashioned a pre-existing relationship.